

2, It is Necessary to Distinguish Between Political Efficiency and Social Efficiency

Another highly meaningful reflection for me is my current realization that the so-called **political efficiency** (政治效率) is indeed fundamentally distinct from **social efficiency** (社会效率).

Here, the term "**social efficiency**" refers to the proportion of the **social surplus** (社会剩余) that is utilized for expanded reproduction, technological investment (including investments in basic sciences, engineering, culture, arts, education, etc.), the improvement of public services and welfare, the advancement of humanitarian causes, and the promotion of consumption. These two forms of efficiency are frequently and deliberately conflated within our country's discourse. For instance, our official propaganda relentlessly claims that Western democratic countries are extremely inefficient, that their governments are perpetually in an unstable state, and that internal ideological polarization makes it difficult for them to adopt unified measures. Consequently, it asserts that our own political system is immensely efficient, having achieved brilliant developmental successes under visionary, unified leadership. In this context, the "efficiency" emphasized by our political propaganda is almost exclusively **political efficiency**.

Over the past six months, however, I have clearly realized that the social development of humanity must be grounded in long-term evolutionary trends. Therefore, on the fundamental issue of determining the rise and fall of nations, **social efficiency** is the decisive factor—the ultimate determinant of success or failure. The extent to which the **social surplus** can be utilized for productive accumulation and technological investment directly dictates the speed at which a society can develop and progress, which in turn determines the degree of development and liberation each individual can achieve.

Conversely, **political efficiency** is inherently a neutral term. While I naturally understood this intellectually in the past, I admittedly lacked an intuitive grasp of it. Yet, what I have seen, heard, learned, and pondered over the past few years has profoundly shocked me. Now that I clearly comprehend the terrifying magnitude and duration of the crimes a government is capable of committing across vast scopes, the "neutrality" of this term can be fully understood. For a well-functioning society where the government's decisions genuinely reflect the overarching needs of the public, high **political efficiency** is undoubtedly highly beneficial for social development, and **social efficiency** will consequently be elevated. However, when the government's interests are fundamentally aligned with suppressing the society's needs and destroying any potential for change, high **political efficiency** merely means that social production undergoes catastrophic destruction and societal wealth is annihilated more thoroughly. In such scenarios, let alone being "low," it is entirely possible for **social efficiency** to be reduced to zero over the long term.

In fact, we can observe that, aside from the developmental stages no later than those of **early slavery** (早期的奴隶制) states, natural forces—namely, disasters that humans cannot contain or predict, or the severe scarcity of critical resources (which was notably evident in pre-Columbian Mesoamerica)—could cause human society to stagnate or even regress for long periods. Once humanity, on the eve of the emergence of the **classical empire** (古典帝国), achieved significant elevations in metal smelting techniques and noticeably advanced its capacity to transform nature (marked by the expansions of Ancient Greece, China's Zhou Dynasty, and the Indo-Aryans, as discussed in Part One), regional natural disasters could no longer halt the intrinsic progress of civilization, provided they were not global cataclysms.

This was largely because the geographical scope of civilization itself had expanded. For example, when the Aegean civilization was primarily confined to islands like Crete, a single volcanic eruption was sufficient to cause a devastating impact. However, when the Ancient Greeks established colonial city-states "ubiquitously" along the Mediterranean coast (the term "ubiquitously" being an exaggeration, of course), a natural disaster of the previous scale was no longer sufficient to inflict a fatal blow upon this civilization.

Thus, we can clearly see that since entering the era of classical states, there has been fundamentally only one root cause for the stagnation or even regression of civilization: the generation of a "cancer cell" within the civilization itself. This manifests as a colossal rentier class, epitomized by an unabated **bureaucratic system** (官僚体制), which consumes almost the entirety of the **social surplus**, driving the civilization's **social efficiency** down to near zero.

We can (somewhat loosely) draw an analogy between this transformation and the growth of the human body. When a person is very young, their immune system is highly immature; at this stage, the greatest threats to their life are external injuries and pathogenic microorganisms. However, in today's era of advanced medicine, people no longer have to resign themselves to fate upon falling ill as the ancients did, and average life expectancy has more than doubled compared to two millennia ago. Consequently, in old age, individuals must increasingly confront diseases caused by the dysfunction of their own bodily systems, with cancer being the prime representative. Can one claim that a cancer cell is a cell lacking in vitality? Obviously not. Cancer cells do not lack vitality; rather, they possess far too much of it. It is just that their vitality constitutes an absolute disaster for the human body itself.

The numerous examples cited previously also demonstrate that in an abnormal **bureaucratic state** (官僚国家), the higher the **political efficiency** (政治效率), the less likely it is for **social efficiency** (社会效率) to be high, and the greater the price the entire society must pay. Formally speaking, the total volume of the **social surplus** (社会剩余) multiplied by the society's **social efficiency** equals the total volume of effective investment in that society; this total volume, in turn, directly determines the quality and quantity of inventions and innovations.

Therefore, we can easily answer a fundamental question: why can small nations achieve monumental feats, while many large nations with massive populations and vast territories behave like giants with feet of clay? If we observe ancient Egypt and ancient Greece during the final millennium BCE, although the total population of Egypt might have been more massive than that of the core region of ancient Greek civilization, and the lands along both banks of the Nile River were even more fertile, the **social efficiency** (社会效率) possessed by Egyptian society at that time was probably barely above zero. In contrast, ancient Greek society exhibited a high **social efficiency** rarely seen in the entire ancient world. Consequently, in absolute terms, the Greeks held a distinct advantage in productive accumulation and technological investment, which explains why they could create such astonishing civilizational achievements. The examples contrasting the European Christian states during the Middle Ages with a colossal entity like China are even more glaring. Although China's total wealth and **social surplus** were massive, the proportion that could be effectively utilized was virtually non-existent. Under such circumstances, expecting it to achieve greater development than Europe is a delusion, not to mention that the royal court fundamentally opposed and repelled such development anyway.

Admittedly, there are indeed cases where extremely high **political efficiency** was employed to forcibly extract societal wealth and channel it into effective investment, although such examples are pitifully rare. One can easily observe this phenomenon in China during the reign of Emperor Wu of Han. This point is evidenced by the vigorous inventions and rapid social progress in our country during the two centuries spanning the 1st century BCE and the 1st century CE (within a very short period, a trend of **feudalization** [封建化] emerged from within the **classical empire** [古典帝国]—anyone who visits the museums in Shaanxi and Henan to view the terracotta models of large Eastern Han manors will gain a very intuitive understanding of this). This belongs to the reaction made by a **classical state** (古典国家) when confronting intense external stimuli. The fact is, after the Han Dynasty, this historical phenomenon never reappeared in China; all the **restoration-bureaucratic state** (复辟官僚国家) ever did was drag the entire nation backward. Therefore, we can assert that indoctrinating the common people to believe that **political efficiency** is everything, while completely ignoring or obscuring the concept of **social efficiency**, is a quintessential piece of Chinese-style propaganda.

Naturally, we must also point out that a specific relationship exists between **political efficiency** and **social efficiency**. A country with exceedingly low **political efficiency** cannot possibly have high **social efficiency**. This is because excessively low **political efficiency** inherently implies that the society is in a state of turmoil, where stable social relations do not even exist. Let alone utilizing the **social surplus** for expanded production and investment, merely maintaining basic production becomes a problem; naturally, **social efficiency** cannot be high. Conversely, a country with exceedingly low **social efficiency** cannot sustain high **political efficiency** in the long run. Excessively low **social efficiency** means that there exists within the society a massive rentier class armed with political power. To expect these individuals to maintain efficient administration—especially to adopt swift responses when coping with changes—is simply a pipe dream. For anyone who harbors any doubts about this, my advice is to come live in China for three years; I truly see no necessity to offer any further refutation. People often quote British Prime Minister Winston Churchill, saying that democracy is not necessarily the best system, but it is undoubtedly the least bad system.

Actually, in my view, Churchill clearly lost a degree of his nerve when facing Soviet military pressure in the early Cold War. He should have stated with unwavering conviction that the democratic system is simply the best system humanity has thus far witnessed and realized. The significance of this system lies in the fact that, although it cannot achieve immediate compliance through coercive administrative power like some autocratic states, in the long run, it ensures that **social efficiency** (社会效率) can be maintained at a relatively high level. This is because every individual's private property and the fruits of their labor are genuinely respected and protected, granting the people greater freedom for development and choice.

We must further point out that the so-called "political inefficiency" of democratic countries—represented by developed capitalist nations like the United States, the United Kingdom, and France—is merely an illusion inside the minds of the Chinese people; it is the result of the global overarching peace having been maintained for far too long. When the Japanese bombed Pearl Harbor back then, were they not also pinning their hopes on the assumption that the United States—the world's largest democratic country (in terms of scale)—would struggle to rapidly mobilize for a total war? Regardless of what the Japanese thought back then, they have clearly been jolted awake by the aircraft carrier USS Enterprise, which could rapidly return to the battlefield no matter how

heavily it was struck, alongside countless warships and aircraft, inexhaustible ammunition, and two nuclear weapons. Must other countries pay such a massive price as Japan did just to realize this fact?

As for whether **social efficiency** itself can be used as a metric to measure the level of social development, this currently remains an open question. I personally lean towards the view that, excluding the transitional phases between class societies, from **slavery society** (奴隶制社会) to **feudal society** (封建社会), and then to modern **capitalist society** (资本主义社会), the **social efficiency** of each is higher than that of its predecessor. However, I also feel that the precise value of this **social efficiency** cannot, after all, be exactly quantified. To date, there is no effective research methodology for this; therefore, no definitive conclusions can be drawn, and we can only wait to see if better research instruments are developed in the future.

During my contemplation of these two types of efficiencies, and combining this with my previous views on the land issue (namely, that the fundamental requirement of modernization is the decline of land's status among various factors of production, yielding the position of the **primary factor of production** [首位生产要素] to capital), I increasingly feel that when examining a sociological problem, one must strive to grasp the "fundamental quantity" related to the issue, and absolutely avoid being misled by secondary variables and relationships. For example, the transition from **feudalism** (封建主义) to early modern and modern society requires that land lose its paramount position in the socio-economic sphere and yield it to capital. As long as this occurs, regardless of the method used or which class leads it, and despite potential differences in speed and cost, the society will ultimately march towards early modernization/modernization; conversely, it will deviate from it.

The momentum of social progress depends on **social efficiency**. Thus, whether it is autocratic rule implemented by an exceptionally talented monarch like Emperor Wu of Han, or the various types of systems implemented by the numerous city-states of ancient Greece, as long as a high **social efficiency** can be guaranteed for a certain period, substantial strides in social development are an inevitable outcome. This mindset of seeking the "key variable" in a problem closely resembles certain mathematical theorems (such as Gauss's Theorem). We only need to observe the flux of certain key variables across an entire historical period; as for the complex circulation of social structures it undergoes in between, there is no need to be overly concerned about them at the very beginning.

I do not know whether "key variables" universally exist in sociology, but based on my experience of living in China for so long, I can say with absolute certainty: concealing the significance—and even the very existence—of the "key variable," thereby misleading the people into focusing their attention on secondary variables and relationships, is indeed the infallible playbook (不二法门) used by the **bureaucratic state** (官僚国家) to deceive its populace.

2，应当区分政治效率和社会效率

另一个对我来说比较有意义的反思是，我现在认识到所谓政治效率的确不等于社会效率。在这里我说的“社会效率”这个词，指的是社会剩余被用于扩大再生产，进行技术投资（包括对基础科学，工程学，文化，艺术，教育等等的投资），完善公共服务和福利，推进人道主义事业，促进消费的比例。这两个效率在我国的语境中时常被故意混淆，例如我国官方就宣称西方的民主国家是极其低效的，政府总是处于不稳定的状态，而且内部因为意见撕裂而难以采取统一步调。进而声称我国的政治体制是极为高

效的，在高瞻远瞩的统一领导下取得了辉煌的发展成绩。在这里，我国的政治宣传中所强调的效率，几乎清一色的都是政治效率。但是在过去半年的时间里，我清楚地意识到人类的社会发展必然基于长期演变趋势，因此在决定国家兴衰这个根本问题上，社会效率是具有决定性的成败的胜负手。社会剩余能有多大程度用于生产性积累和技术投资，直接决定了这个社会能以多快的速度发展和进步，进而决定了每个人能得到多大的发展和解放。而政治效率是一个中性词汇，虽然在过去我从理智上当然也知道这一点，但是的确是缺乏直观感受的，然而过去几年的所见、所闻、所学、所思给了我很大的震动。现在我清楚地了解到政府能够在多长的时间里多大的范围内犯下多么恐怖的罪行，那么这个词的“中性性”就是可以被完全理解的了。对于运转良好的，政府本身的决策能够反映社会总体需求时，政治效率高对于社会发展当然是一件极有利的事情，社会效率也会因此得到提升。但是当政府的利益压根就是压制这个社会的需求，破坏可能产生的一切变化的话，那么政治效率高就意味着社会生产得到了极大的破坏，社会财富得到了更为充分的销毁，社会效率不要说不高，长期清零也不是做不到的。

其实我们可以观察到，除了在不晚于早期奴隶制国家的发展阶段时自然力量，也就是人类无法遏制和预测的灾害或者关键资源的匮乏（这在前哥伦布时代的美索美洲比较明显）会使得人类社会长期停滞在某一时期甚至退化以外。一旦人类在古典帝国产生的前夜因为金属冶炼的水平得到了提升，改造自然的能力明显上了一个台阶之后（标志就是第一部分所说的，古希腊，中国周朝，以及印度雅利安人的扩张），只要不是全球性的灾变，区域性的自然灾害已经没办法在阻止文明本身的进步。这在很大程度上也是因为文明本身的范围扩大了，例如当爱琴海文明还主要局限在克里特等岛屿的时候，那么一次火山喷发就足以造成毁灭性的影响。但是当古希腊人把殖民城邦建得遍及地中海沿岸（这里的遍及当然是夸大的说法）都是的时候，那么原先规模的自然灾害就不足以对这个文明造成致命打击了。因此我们可以清晰地看到，自从进入古典国家以来，文明的停滞甚至倒退本质原因无非只有一个，那就是文明内部产生了一种“癌细胞”，一个没有正常结束的官僚体制为代表的庞大的几乎消耗了全部社会剩余的食利阶层，使得这个文明的社会效率趋近于零。

可以（不太形象地）把这种变化比拟为人体本身的成长，在一个人很小的时候，体内的免疫系统是很不成熟的，此时对人生造成巨大威胁的是外部的伤害和致病性微生物。但是在医学发达的今天，人们已经不再像古人一样一旦得病就只能听天由命，人均寿命比两千年前涨了一倍不止。因此人们在老年就不得不更多面对自己身体功能失调所造成的疾病，这其中就以癌症为代表。难道一个人能说癌细胞是一种缺乏活力的细胞吗？显然不可以，癌细胞不是没有活力而是太有活力了，只不过它的活力对于人体本身而言就是一种灾难。

之前所举的那么多例子也表明，在一个非正常的官僚国家，政治效率越高，社会效率就越不可能高，整个社会要付出的代价就越大。从形式上看，社会剩余的总量乘以该社会的社会效率就等于该社会的有效投资的总量，这个总量又直接影响了发明创造的质和量。因此我们可以非常容易地回答一个问题，那就是为什么小国也能够成就大业，而许多人口和领土都极为庞大的大国却如同泥足巨人。如果我们观察公元前最后一个千年的古埃及和古希腊，则埃及的总人口虽然可能比古希腊文明核心区的人口更为庞大，尼罗河两岸的土地也更加肥沃，但是当年的埃及社会所具有的社会效率恐怕不比零多太多，而古希腊社会则展现出了整个古代世界少有的高社会效率。因此从总量上看，希腊人在生产性积累和技术投资上明显占优势，因此古希腊人才能创造出令人惊叹的文明成果。至于中世纪时期欧洲基督教国家和中国这样的庞然大物相对比的例子则更为显著了，中国的财富总量虽然庞大，社会剩余虽然庞大，但是能有效利用的几乎没有，在这种情况下妄想取得比欧洲更大的发展是不可能的，更别说朝廷本来也不欢迎这样的发展。

当然确实也有以极高的政治效率去强制吸取社会财富并将其进行有效投资的案例，虽然这样的例子本身少到可怜。人们很容易看到汉武帝时期的中国确实出现了这样的现象，这一点可以被公元前一世纪和公元一世纪200年间我国蓬勃的发明创造和突飞猛进的社会进步（在极短的时间内就由古典帝国内部产生了封建化趋势，如果人们到陕西和河南的博物馆中去看一看东汉时期大型庄园的陶土模型就会有非常直观的感受）所证明。这属于古典国家在应对强力外部刺激时所做出的反应，事实是，在汉代以后中国再也没有出现这样的历史现象，复辟官僚国家所做的不过是拖整个民族的后腿罢了。因此我们可以说，让老百姓认为政治效率就是一切，而完全忽视或者不了解社会效率，就是一种典型的中国式宣传。当然，我们也应该指出政治效率和社会效率之间存在这样一种关系。政治效率过低的国家社会效率不可能高，这是因为过低的政治效率本身就意味着社会处于一种动荡状态，稳定的社会关系甚至都不存在，不要说

把社会剩余用来扩大生产和投资，恐怕连维持生产都已经成为问题了，社会效率自然是高不了的。反过来说，社会效率过低的国家政治效率也无法长期维持高位，社会效率过低意味着社会内部存在一个非常大的拥有政治权力的食利阶层，指望这些人维持高效的行政特别是在应对变化时采取迅捷的反应简直是做梦，对这件事情有任何疑问的人我的建议是来中国生活三年即可，实在是看不到有任何反驳的必要。人们常常引用英国首相丘吉尔的话说，民主未必是最好的制度，但一定是最不坏的制度。

其实在我看来，丘吉尔在冷战初期面对苏联的军事压力时明显失掉了一些胆色，他应该以毫不怀疑的口吻说，现在民主制度就是人类所能看到的，已经实现的最好的制度。这种制度的意义在于它固然不能够像一些专制国家一样以强制的行政力量实现令行禁止，但是从长久来看它确保了社会效率能够维持到较高水平，因为每个人的私有财产也好，劳动成果也罢确实受到了尊重和保护，人民具有更多发展和选择的自由。我们更应该指出，以美国，英国，法国这样的发达资本主义国家为代表的民主国家所谓在政治上的低效不过是中国人脑中的幻想罢了，是全世界总体和平局面维持太久的结果。当年日本人轰炸珍珠港的时候，他们是否也寄希望于美国这个世界最大（从规模上说）的民主国家难以快速地应对一场总体战争呢？不管日本人当年怎么想，他们现在显然已经被无论怎么炸都能快速重回战场的企业号航母，数不尽的战舰飞机，打不完的弹药，以及两枚核武器给炸醒了。难道其他国家非得像日本一样付出这么大的代价才能意识到这一点吗？至于社会效率本身是否能够用来衡量社会发展水平这一点目前存疑，我个人倾向于不考虑阶级社会之间的过渡阶段，那么从奴隶制社会到封建社会，再到现代的资本主义社会，每一个的社会效率都要高于前一个。但是我又觉得这一社会效率的值毕竟不可能精确地得到，迄今为止也没有什么有效的研究方法，因此也不能给出什么论断，只能看看将来是否有人发掘更好的研究手段。

我在思考两种效率的问题的过程中，结合之前对于土地问题（即近现代化的根本要求在于土地在各生产要素中的地位下降，并将首位生产要素让给资本）的看法，越来越感觉当人们考量一个社会学问题的时候，应当注意去抓住与问题相关的“根本量”，而千万不要被一些次要的量和关系所迷惑。例如从封建主义到近现代社会的过渡要求土地在社会经济中占据的首要地位丧失并让位于资本，那么无论是用什么方式，由哪个阶级主导，虽然在速度和成本上会有差异，但是最终总会迈向近现代社会，反之则会背离现代化。社会进步的力度取决于社会效率，那么无论是像汉武帝这样才能卓越的君主实施专制统治，还是古希腊的诸多城邦国家所实施的不同种类的制度，只要能够保证一定时期内的高社会效率，社会发展取得长足进展都是必然的结果。这种找问题中的“关键量”的思维看起来很像数学中的一些定理（比如高斯定理），我们只观察通过整个历史时期的一些关键量的通量即可，至于其中经过了怎样复杂的社会结构流转，则在最初没必要关心太多。我不知道“关键量”在社会学中是否普遍存在，但是我以我在中国生活了这么久的经验可以很肯定地说，隐藏“关键量”的意义乃至存在，误导人们把注意力放到次要的量和关系上，的确是官僚国家欺骗百姓的不二法门。